

GS Passive & Reporting

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

The passive voice and reporting structures allow you to present information, evidence, and claims with appropriate attribution and distance. At ILR 3, these structures are not evasion — they are precision. When you say 'it has been argued that' or 'studies have shown,' you are signaling the source and status of the claim. When you use the passive to focus on the outcome rather than the actor, you are making a deliberate analytical choice. These structures allow you to position evidence carefully and distance yourself from claims you are reporting rather than endorsing.

WHAT TO TRY

- Use passive constructions to foreground outcomes rather than actors: 'funding was redirected to...'
- Use reporting verbs to attribute claims accurately: it has been argued, researchers have found, critics suggest
- Distinguish between what is claimed and what you endorse: 'while it is often stated that... the evidence indicates...'
- Use passive + by-phrase when the actor is analytically important: 'decisions were made by those least affected'
- Use hedged reporting to present contested findings: 'some studies suggest... though others have found...'

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "It has been argued that... however, this claim has not been fully supported by..."
- "Research conducted in similar contexts has shown that..."
- "This position is often justified on the grounds that... but it can also be challenged by..."
- "When the burden is placed on individuals rather than institutions, outcomes tend to..."
- "It is widely assumed that... though this assumption has been questioned by..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Who bears responsibility for climate change adaptation?

*"It is often argued that individual behavior change is the most effective lever for addressing climate change, but **this claim has been challenged by** researchers **who have found that** systemic factors account for the majority of emissions. **When responsibility is assigned primarily to individuals**, the structural conditions **that shape those choices are left unaddressed**. **It has been shown that** communities with the least historical contribution to emissions **are disproportionately affected by** its consequences — a dynamic **that is rarely acknowledged** in policy debates **dominated by** high-emission economies."*

Bold phrases mark active passive and reporting moves — attributing claims, focusing on outcomes, and positioning evidence with precision.